

Faxian, Xuanzang and Yijing in India

(400–700 CE)

I don't know many books in which 'Go west, young man!' would be a call to go to India. One such book is *Journey to the West*, 'China's most beloved novel of religious quest and picaresque adventure', published in the 1590s during the waning years of the Ming Dynasty. The novel's hero, 'a mischievous monkey with human traits . . . accompanies the monk hero on his action-filled travels to India in search of Buddhist scripture'. It allegorically presents pilgrims journeying towards India as individuals journeying towards enlightenment.[1]

The inspiration for this novel was a journey made by a seventh-century-CE Chinese man, Xuanzang (aka Hiuen Tsang), a Buddhist monk who embarked on an adventurous seventeen-year trip to India, part of which he spent at Nalanda Mahavihara, a great Buddhist centre of learning. Other Chinese Buddhists had visited India before Xuanzang, and many more would follow, but three pilgrims left records of their journeys that would survive, giving us vital portraits of the Indian social and religious life between 400 and 700 CE. These are Faxian (aka Fa-Hien, c. 337– 422 CE), Xuanzang (c. 602–664 CE) and Yijing (635–713 CE).[2] All three of them began their journeys in Chang'an (modern Xian), a multicultural hotspot and terminus of the Silk Road. They went as pilgrims seeking Buddhist